DRAFT, DO NOT CITE Bipartisan Concerns about Data Centers in Texas

ALI ALKHATIB✉, University of Texas at Austin, USA
HALEY TRIEM, University of Texas at Austin, USA
DAVID GRAY WIDDER, University of Texas at Austin, USA

As popular resistance to AI increases, research into people's feelings about "AI" often renders to the periphery the physical sites that make generative AI possible, although that has begun to change in the past few years. This trend toward the investigation of the material and infrastructural impacts of AI on nearby communities has accelerated with the proliferation of multi-gigawatt ("hyperscale") data centers broadly characterized as necessary for generative AI model training and operation. Community impact is not equal across locations; more than 200 AI data centers have been proposed in the state of Texas alone in 2026, and pending applications for electrical service exceed the state's capacity for electricity production several times over.

This paper explores Texans' opinions and concerns about hyperscale data centers, and in particular how data center developers engage in what can be described broadly as "dislocating practices" — for instance, the exploitation of bureaucratic and administrative gaps to twist and problematize regulatory exemptions; the use of strategic opacity to advance hyperscale data center projects using non-disclosure agreements or via affiliate or shell companies; and characterizations of the impacts of hyperscale facilities that appear to lessen the utilization of certain resources, but in reality mostly shifts them around strategically. We interviewed 20 Texans across a range of political commitments and affiliations, engaged in various degrees of organizing and activism around data centers in and around their communities. We found that many people with concerns about hyperscale data centers across the political spectrum engage in deliberate locating work, such as focusing organizing around "site fights", forming intentional coalitional alliances that are grounded in the particular setting, and sharing notes and observations with one another to develop concerted strategies and collectively make sense of developments. We conclude with reflections informed by these findings to attempt to help organizers and researchers more productively think about tensions between *AI* and the *data centers* that AI necessitates.

Additional Key Words and Phrases: AI, Data Centers, Hyperscale

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1 Introduction

The ascent of artificial intelligence (AI) and particularly generative AI has dramatically changed economic, social, and political landscapes in just a few short years. AI-powered tools and services, integrated across a wide range of industries and domains, have utterly devastated some professions and disciplines and amplified or even created others [28]. Generative AI has touched labor [9], education [14], romance [2] , and a slew of other areas of social life. Along the way, scholars have carefully observed and studied how the many constellations of technologies we call "AI" have impacted people [10], and designers and developers have suggested ways to more productively integrate this multifaceted "AI"-thing into the lives of everyday people [26, 32]. While research on the *impact* of AI products is critical, studying the mechanisms necessary to develop and deploy AI is equally as insightful to understanding its current and future impacts.

Authors' Contact Information: Ali Alkhatib, ali.alkhatib@utexas.edu, University of Texas at Austin, Austin, Texas, USA; Haley Triem, TK@utexas.edu, University of Texas at Austin, Austin, Texas, USA; David Gray Widder, TK@utexas.edu, University of Texas at Austin, Austin, Texas, USA.

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A considerably smaller, though rapidly growing, community of researchers have been investigating the infrastructural and logistical arrangements necessary to make AI possible [6, 21]. Researchers have studied and discussed some of the material dimensions of "Big Data" for more than a decade [17]. The physical sites where AI is made possible have been an increasingly conspicuous field site for research, especially as these field sites have grown in physical scale and importance, and as their day-to-day operations have become increasingly secretive. The cohesion of the public's consciousness around "hyperscale data centers" — broadly speaking, a mostly-unoccupied computing facility that exceeds 1 gigawatt of energy capacity - has helped bring focus to the impacts these data centers have on the lives of people who live near these structures.

Hyperscale data centers as critical infrastructure for AI represents an interesting contrast because the two objects of inquiry — AI on one hand, and hyperscale data centers on the other — seem to produce a contrast: Others have argued that the project of AI is to produce knowledge, or intelligence, that is fundamentally *not situated* within the lived experience of those creating and using AI, to borrow language from Haraway [16]. Efforts to dislocate conceptual and infrastructural components of the "AI supply chain" have been studied, but dislocations don't resolve problems; they just compartmentalize them [30].

Still, the conflict of AI and data centers — a fundamentally dislocating project versus the necessarily-located infrastructure that makes it possible — produces friction that may be productive for analytical and theoretical work. The sudden and accelerating development of hyperscale data centers has led to a number of local, statewide, and national organizing efforts to steer or stop proposals. Some cities have passed moratoria preventing the development of data centers within the boundaries of those cities [20]; some states, such as New York, Maryland, Virginia, and a handful of others have introduced or passed temporary moratoria on data centers approaching "hyperscale" status [24]. Hyperscale data centers have faced substantial opposition across a myriad of sources and dimensions of sited concerns [18, 27].

Texas has seen a rapid growth of hyperscale data center project that cannot be understated, that may only be clearly perceptible via the impact data centers will have on electricity demand and generation. It also serves as a unique subject for this topic, as Texas's electricity grid is isolated from the interconnections shared between the rest of the U.S. The Electric Reliability Council of Texas (ERCOT), which operates the state's electrical grid, reports close to 500 gigawatts of energy hookup requests in their queue, approximately 90% of which are associated with data centers [11]. These hookup requests may or may not materialize: requests do not mean a data center or other facility is ready to start consuming energy or even built. Still, if as little as 10% of the requests ultimately materialize in real-world demand, energy production capacity in Texas — already the country's leading energy producer by a wide margin — will need to approximately double to keep up [1].

Developers have been proposing and breaking ground on hyperscale data center projects all over the state, much to the chagrin of Texans, who mostly don't want to live near them. Polling from 2025 found that only 31% of Texans support the construction of a data center in their neighborhood; Republicans were slightly more supportive than other Texans, but the prospect of living near a data center was already "underwater" even a year ago [4]. In August 2026 Texas Governor Greg Abbott, up for reelection in November 2026, directed ERCOT to pause data center permitting requests and conduct an audit of the impacts of data centers on the electrical infrastructure of the state as well as their impact on neighboring communities. That audit, and the end of the pause on data center permitting, is expected in early December 2026.

It is against the backdrop of rapid AI evolution and deployment, infrastructural dislocation, hyperscale data centers, and questions on resource use and management that we conduct our research. We spoke with 20 Texans variously engaged in organizing efforts in their communities and across the state to learn about their concerns around this topic.

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We asked about their feelings toward AI, about their thoughts toward data centers, about the answers and promises data center developers have made to their communities, and about a wide range of other issues.

We find that Texans with concerns and frustrations about data centers express a wide range of feelings about AI, but their issues with data centers — specifically the hyperscale data centers that make AI possible — provide a grounding framework around which Texans with myriad political commitments and affiliations can agree. Their feelings toward data center developers center around the sense that developers misleadingly and sometimes dishonestly characterize how hyperscale data centers will impact the communities where they'll actually be located, for instance by decomposing the data center into sub-components that allow for more expedited permitting processes; by administratively "sneaking" infrastructure into the community under different guises; and by shifting certain resource utilization, such as water usage, off-site to appear superficially as though the data center is using less water when in reality it continues to implicate enormous scales of water use. All of these practices can be read as a kind of dislocated logic — the use of administrative & political strategies to abstract or discretize various impacts or issues with data centers — that collides with reality, where this decomposition and dislocation does little to abate the impact of hyperscale data centers on those living near them.

2 Background

To appreciate the broader context within which Texas data center organizing is happening, we look to the conditions that make hyperscale data centers viable, as well as the political and economic environment that supports and rewards these architectures and approaches. Kim illustrates how standardized, abstracted software patterns enable massive hyperscale computing [19]. Greene's work unpacking the history of data centers and internet infrastructure helps us understand how various elements of the web, and now AI, have become financialized assets that reward the kind of abstraction that Kim later describes [15]. Hogan highlights the connection between more abstract concerns like privacy and surveillance and material concerns, notably water, while calling attention to the indelible mark data centers leave on their respective sites — "merging with the landscape, relying on it, and altering it" [17]. This extractive cycle plays out in myriad ways — via accelerator programs, investments into physical infrastructure, and strategic international investments that provide "Big Cloud" firms the ability to entrench consumers deeper into a state of dependence on these companies [29]. Collectively, these works begin to paint a clearer picture of the simultaneous appeal of abstraction and financialization and arrangement of data and computational capacity for web and later AI applications, and some of the parallel investments and other financial practices that produce vertically integrated industries.

Parallel to research into the political-economy data centers and related infrastructures, we juxtapose work exploring motivations and strategies connected to data center refusal and organizing around the world. Barakat et al. highlight the rapidity of the development of hyperscale data center projects in the past few years, highlighting the impacts of data center development across multiple continents and drawing conclusions about how organizers, activists, researchers, and institutions might move forward [5]. Other researchers offer more located analysis on specific sites of opposition and refusal, and draw situated analyses from their engagement with those fights [31].

We engage with AI as a project of alienation of workers from labor [22], but also more broadly the alienation of local knowledge in the interest of a faux-objective systematization of the world [3]. Through that lens, we find feminist scholarship that problematizes knowledge ostensibly presented without a site [16]. In reality, it is perhaps more accurate to say that what is happening — in contrast to locating oneself — is the dislocation of knowledge, or the dislocation of the self. Dislocation can happen in myriad ways, but we tentatively offer that dislocation can be observed in discretization and models that reduce and abstract phenomenological experience and knowledge. Dislocation may be characterized by

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a constellation of phenomena including compartmentalization or fracturing of harms that might be better-understood through their relationships and interactions with one another; or may take the form of conditions of isolation that undermine collective sense-making and collective action.

Hyperscale data centers as critical infrastructure for AI represents an interesting contrast because the two objects of inquiry — AI on one hand, and hyperscale data centers on the other — seem to produce a contrast: If the project of AI is to produce knowledge, or intelligence, that is fundamentally *not situated* within the lived experience of those creating and using AI, to borrow language from Haraway [16], then hyperscale data centers are intriguing because they represent a literal place in the world where AI materializes in computer hardware and infrastructure. Researchers have studied efforts to dislocate conceptual and infrastructural components of the "AI supply chain", concluding that dislocations don't resolve problems; they just tend to compartmentalize them; nevertheless, that that compartmentalization and dislocation can be strategically useful [30].

We can begin to characterize Texans' responses to the arrival of hyperscale data centers over the past several years. A small and shrinking constituency of Texans supported the construction of a data center in their community or neighborhood in a survey conducted in 2025 [4]. In light of the overwhelming unpopularity of data centers, the then-governor of Texas, Greg Abbott, issued a moratorium on data centers focusing on the regulatory power to pause the approval of electricity service hookup applications [1], although the details around that moratorium, and in particular the governor's earnestness in enforcing it, has been the subject of some investigation and reporting [13]. This opposition has been productive; observers of the AI industry, including avid investors, have begun to notice that many of the AI hyperscale data centers formally proposed over the past several have not materialized, in part due to organizing efforts against these projects [12]. Still, Texas remains one of the fastest-growing sites of hyperscale data center development, rapidly catching up with and overtaking Virginia, home to a cluster of mostly defense-related technology companies and data center facilities sometimes known colloquially as "Data Center Alley" [23].

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3 Methods

Participants were recruited through the help of data center activism stakeholders who disseminated a screener survey to social media groups. The screener survey consisted of minimal demographic information (e.g. first name, county, and occupation), questions about data center proximity, and questions about the participant's political ideology (simplified, for the survey, to "left-of-center," "center," and "right-of-center").

We conducted semi-structured interviews (n=20) via phone call and Zoom. Authors followed an interview script for question consistency, although we retained flexibility to follow interesting conversational threads or to adjust questions. Interviews were recorded and transcribed, then shared among co-authors for analysis. This project is classified as exempt-level human subjects research, and was approved by our university's institutional review board (IRB) department prior to outreach.

We analyzed interview transcripts using thematic analysis [7], with authors first open-coding the interviews independently and then collapsing open codes into common themes as a research team. Then, we returned to the transcripts and applied the thematic code book. Analysis occurred in tandem with interviews, with the authors meeting several times per week to discuss reflections on interviews and present open coding we had developed. Thus, given the iterative and highly conversational nature of our analysis, and its overlap with data collection, we found metrics such as inter-coder reliability to be inappropriate.

We interviewed participants during the first half of October 2026, an especially interesting time for this topic as it directly precedes the 2026 U.S. midterm election, where all 435 House of Representatives and one-third of the 100

P#	Work	Political Category	Texas Region	Concerns
C1	Environmental Engineer	Center	Central	Lowered property value
C2	Quality Assurance Document Associate	Center	Central	Water, electricity, air quality, community health
C3	Self-employed	Center	North Central	Water, electricity, propaganda
C4	Life Insurance Administrator	Center	North Central	Building financing and obsolescence
L1	Corporate Compliance and Business Development	Left-of-Center	Central	Water, environment, surveillance
L2	Administrator	Left-of-Center	Central	Water, power, pollution
L3	AI Futurist	Left-of-Center	Central	Water, power, local citizens
L4	Unemployed	Left-of-Center	South Central	Power, water, pollution
L5	Environmental Attorney	Left-of-Center	Central	Water and energy
L6	Community Organizer	Left-of-Center	North	Environment, economy, and community needs
L7	Restaurant Owner	Left-of-Center	Central	Water and electricity
L8	Body Piercer	Left-of-Center	Central	Water, electricity, surveillance
L9	Research and Instruction	Left-of-Center	Central	Environment
R1	Luxury Retail Worker	Right-of-Center	Panhandle	Power and water
R2	Retired	Right-of-Center	North	Sound, light, and water pollution
R3	Nonprofit Director	Right-of-Center		Surveillance and fire hazards
R4	Retired	Right-of-Center	North	Water and human health
R5	Community Organizer	Right-of-Center	South	Water; noise, light, and air pollution
R6	Retired	Right-of-Center	South	Surveillance and the well being of future generations
R7	Truck Driver	Right-of-Center	Panhandle	Water and labor

Table 1. Participant overview of participants, illustrating very wide ranges of professions, political affiliations, and broadly characterized self-described concerns regarding data centers.

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Senate seats are being voted on. Politics are certainly on peoples' mind as we write this, with political advertisements consistently running and candidate signs populating front yards and windows. We did not explicitly ask participants about the midterms, but in many conversations the elections came up as a temporal marker within the process of data center resistance.

The first and second authors attended a data center community meeting after completing most of the interviews, and found that many of the themes we discussed during analysis were echoed in the meeting. The second author also attended the Texas Energy Summit on October 26-28 in the state capital, where audience questions revolved around similar themes presented in our paper. Although we do not include quotes from that meeting in this paper, as we did not formally interview event attendees, we found that both events reflected patterns distilled from our participant interviews and served as external and early validation of our findings.

4 Findings

We started each interview by asking participants why they were concerned with data centers. We spoke with 20 participants across Texas who had expressed concerns about data centers. Participants came from all over the state, living in cities, suburbs, and rural areas, in the last case often on farmland. Politically, 9 self-identified as left of center, 7

as right of center, and 4 as "center". Participants were working in retail, food, health insurance administration, law, or retired, unemployed, or were in various stages education.

People's concerns about data centers were rooted in myriad issues: several named the environmental degradation of the landscape that they cherished (R5, R6, L1, L3, L5, C4); some participants were concerned about the impacts that large-scale facilities may have on people living near these facilities (L2, L3, L7, C4); others were concerned that access to natural resources would be jeopardized by a hyperscale data center nearby (C2, C4, R4, R5); others still rejected capitalist schemes of organizing the means of production (L6, L8). Some people connected issues about data centers to Palestine (L6), others to Flock (R3, L6, L7, L8) or surveillance more broadly (L1, R6). Many participants named "Big Tech" broadly (R6, R4, C3, L8), or named specific companies such as Anthropic, Meta, Google, and OpenAI with some degree of negativity (C4, L4, R7, L1, R4, L3, C1, L2, R2, L7), or specific tech figures such as Elon Musk (L4, R7, R3, L3, L5, R2, L7), who had moved himself and many of his companies to the state in recent years. After noting the above demographic patterns and reasons for data center concern, we open-coded interviews and collapsed codes into broader themes. Across these themes, our participants emerged ebbing and flowing tides of *dislocating* and locating tactics, as employed by developers and activists in the Texas data center showdown. In the following sections, we detail developers' dislocating practices (4.1), activists' locating counter-practices (4.2), and the convergence of the two (4.3).

4.1 Data center developers engage in dislocating practices

Participants felt hyperscale data center developers intentionally introduce dislocations — in other words, the abstraction, fracturing, and alienation discussed in section 2 — into communities via a number of mechanisms and strategies. We describe a number of ways that we observe dislocation in communities as precipitated by hyperscale data centers: (1) the feeling that hyperscale data centers create crises out of local regulatory conditions that allow space for exploitation; (2) the creation of opacity among members of communities via legalistic tools such as non-disclosure agreements; and (3) the perception that the impacts of hyperscale data centers are not being comprehensively or candidly reported.

4.1.1 Participants describe how data centers appear to exploit regulatory gaps, creating states of ongoing crisis. We spoke with a number of participants who felt that data center developers were exploiting gaps or loopholes in regulatory and oversight regimes to make it possible to get facilities developed more rapidly, under less scrutiny, or in more accommodating conditions than they would otherwise endure.

Concerns about the exploitation of regulatory gaps were particularly notable as several participants discussed so-called "peaker plants" to us. Peaker plants are power generation facilities built to provide energy to the community during periods of exceptional demand ("peaks"), such as during a heat wave or a cold snap. They are under less regulatory scrutiny in order to rapidly accommodate exceptional environmental conditions, typically for the benefit of community safety. The state's energy grid is isolated from the rest of the country's grid, and as a result, emergency energy needs must be handled internally. This quality of the Texas infrastructure has complicated crises in the recent past, such as in February 2021 when Winter Storm Uri led to statewide power outages and severe food & water shortages and hundreds of resulting deaths, with impacts felt most acutely in predominantly minority communities [25].

Participants noted how the relaxed regulatory conditions of peaker plants could be, and likely were, exploited by data center developers. One participant spoke to us about the creeping arrival of data center projects in their community, and their suspicion that the nearby peaker plant was built with the ultimate goal of powering a data center that later broke ground: "…the peaker plant is up and running, which we do think was probably sold as a 'peak time' plant, but really probably was for the AI data [center]." (L7). Living in the same community, L2 put it more forcefully: "It was

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snuck in as a peaker plant. [...] within a year, they doubled [the capacity]." (L2). L7 explained their frustration with the creeping nature of data center developers getting hyperscale datacenter projects approved by decomposing them into pieces: "minor permits that should be major permits [...] but because they're doing it in phases, it's just gonna be a warehouse, and they don't know what this warehouse is gonna be for [...] then they can start looking into air and and water permits [...] then a warehouse and a subdivision. Suddenly, it's a hyperscale data center." (L7).

Participants across the state were able to offer a sense of the implications of "sneaking" peaker plants into a community; L1, more than an hour away from the aforementioned L2 & L7 participants, had been organizing against a proposal for "...an air permit [...] for like 49 gas-powered generators..." (L1); numerous participants (L2, L3, L4, L7, & C4) brought up concerns around the health implications of living near peaker plants, specifically naming cancer and fears (in L7's case) of recreating a "Cancer Alley" (L7) (referencing a 200-mile stretch of land along the Mississippi River where cancer rates are more than 40 times greater than the acceptable threshold in the United States — described by some legal scholars as a "decades-long human rights crisis" [8]. Opportunistic classifications of peaker plants, dislocated from their intended purpose and instead used to support data center development, had the potential to exploit regulation from something communally beneficial into something harmful.

L7 identifies that the mere existence of a hyperscale data center appears to create perpetual conditions of "peak demand" that give pretext to operate peaker plants nearly-continuously, at the expense of neighbors' health: "does that [data center] not make it [the energy grid] peak *all the time*? [...peak means] you can run it that way without getting permits" (L7). C1 expressed a similar frustration toward a data center developer in their community, about 100 miles north of L7, which separated elements of the data center into sub-components so that, in this case the power generation infrastructure, could be approved with less scrutiny: "...how are you going to separate the power that's running the data center from the data center itself, if it's built for that purpose?" (C1).

What we find here is the exploitation of permitting processes for "minor" projects, the exploitation of gaps and accommodations meant for power generation plants that address "peak" demand and exceptional conditions, and what we argue is an expansion of logics that were never designed to be abstractly exploited in this way. What participants appear to be responding to, across political ideological commitments and across communities, is a dislocation of the paradigms of governance that Texans were otherwise able to bear before the arrival of hyperscale data center developers.

4.1.2 Participants report that data center developers exploit opacity in myriad ways. Participants expressed frustration with how hyperscale data center developers appeared to be affecting local relationships, particularly by non-disclosure agreements, and locking local governments into financial arrangements to alleviate budgetary crises.

Numerous participants told us about unsuccessful attempts to learn more about the terms of a hyperscale data center proposal. — for instance, in C1's case, to learn more about a neighbor's decision to lease enormous tracts of land adjacent to C1's home for power generation for a data center. In many of these cases (L1, R1, & C1), non-disclosure agreements (NDAs) came up prominently as a tool data center developers have used seemingly to prevent parties from communicating with one another or piecing together certain information.

Indeed, NDAs loomed in the minds of participants looking for more information about data center proposals from others in their community: L1 told us of data center projects in their county where "...there's been a lot of speculation. Uh, they are behind NDA, of course." (L1); R2 reflected on their feeling of failure to stop an active data center project that managed to break ground before NDAs or other plans emerged: "...because of the NDA, no one knew anything about it." (R2). C1, who had been personally investigating the unanticipated sale of land surrounding their home to power generation firms, reflected on the revelation that their neighbor had apparently been committed to secrecy: "...[my

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neighbor] had told me that he had to sign an NDA [2 years ago]." (C1). Whether NDAs can be enforced or not, they placed individuals in positions of relative informational isolation and frustrated and antagonized entire communities. L8 characterized data center developers as "…very secretive about a lot of things." (L8); R6, on the other side of the political aisle, shared L8's sentiments and relayed a local government official's exhortation: "One of the commissioners, he said, 'the citizens have been asking y'all [data center developers] for transparency and accountability and that they want to meet with you and they want to hear from you.'" (R6).

In other politically contested issues within these communities, participants seemed to feel that they could have forthright conversations and ultimately reach amicable arrangements with neighbors. What we seem to find is the injection of legalistic tools to denature the located relationships and logics that previously or otherwise might have prevailed. The economic and political conditions around hyperscale data centers seem to bring with them tendencies to disrupt relationships in favor of an ultimately fungible resource: enormous amounts of money.

4.1.3 Participants feel data center developers misrepresent the impacts of data centers. Finally, we found that participants were skeptical of the promises data center developers and proponents made around the mitigation of hyperscale facilities' impacts. Participants spoke about several topics that we can report on here. (1) closed loop cooling; (2) heat islands; (3) noise mitigation; and (4) air quality.

One of the pressing issues with hyperscale data centers — after the aforementioned elephant in the room that is power generation (see section 4.1.1 for more discussion on "peaker plants") — is how to deal with the enormous amounts of heat that data centers produce, especially at this scale and concentration. Lately, the promise of "closed loop" cooling systems has emerged as a potential solution to the problem of the torrential amounts of water that are necessary to operate conventional "open loop" or evaporative cooling facilities. A closed loop system promises, ostensibly, to use dramatically less water as the theoretical application doesn't necessitate circulation or flushing of water.

C3 told us about their frustration of reading and learning about data centers, and hearing from "…people in tech […] or proponents of data centers, constantly pretending they don't have to use water to run the electricity that operates these things…" (C3). L2 raised the same point: "…normally when they save on water like that […] require more power generation as well." (L2). L7 told us that "…to use a closed loop system, you're gonna have to use more electricity, which uses more [water]…" (L7); R5 told us that the turbines used for power generation use "…about 5 times as much water [but that] the data center developers want to decouple that from their actual water use." (R5).

Across a number of these interviews, participants explained that the dramatically higher energy demands of closed loop cooling facilities merely implicates power plants further, which also use enormous amounts of freshwater to generate energy, negating the supposed benefit of closed loop facilities. From the perspectives of several participants we spoke with, the promise of "closed loop" seemed to amount to little more than an administrative trick to obscure the true water usage by rendering "on-site water utilization" off-site to a power generation facility. The impact to their local watershed would only appear to be mitigated on paper; in reality, for those that actually live in the area, the consequences would be the same.

Participants named a number of other issues that they were concerned about: "heat islands" driving up temperatures up as far as several miles away the facility itself (L2, L5, L6); noise disrupting people's sleep (C2, R2, R5, L2, L8) and the well-being of livestock and wild animals (C2, C3, R3, L2, L7, L8); and impacts to air quality (C2, C4, L2, R5, L7).

In all of these examples, data center developers either minimize or reject the impact these facilities will have on the local setting — on the local community's ability to live in the area with elevated temperatures, on the ability of the community to sleep and live healthily in the proximity of continuous data center operations, and on the ability of

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the local animal life to adjust to the presence and footprint of hyperscale data centers. Specifically, proponents and advocates do what C3 referred to as "pretending" that the decomposed impacts of sub-components of data centers — such as the substantially increased need for power generation — won't ultimately be borne by the people, livestock, and wildlife in the area.

Moreover, we found among participants a considerable degree of skepticism — across political views; across geographic location; and across education, socioeconomic status, and class — towards data center developers and "Big Tech" companies as honest actors. Instead, participants seemed to become increasingly accustomed to the expectation that developers and advocates blurred the on-paper accounting of hyperscale facilities so that water usage & electrical demand in particular — but also air quality and other dimensions that would affect quality of life and environment — could shift and flex depending on whether developers wanted to downplay one metric or the other.

4.2 Locating practices

We find a number of ways that people locate and connect knowledge about data center projects to their settings, and situate that knowledge in a broader landscape for the purpose of effectively organizing: (1) participation in parallel "site fights"; (2) sharing information and providing mutual aid; and (3) managing political and ideological commitments and coalitions. This section illustrates the work people do to bring data centers back from the realm of the dislocated, nebulous, even ideological space where conversations around AI are more conceptual and influenced by partisanship. Instead; the overarching theme of the findings we report here illustrate a reticence to let data centers become a matter of "capital-p Political" contestation, keeping the question of hyperscale data centers located squarely within the boundaries of the site proposal in question.

4.2.1 Participants focus on "site fights" and supporting one another in concurrent efforts. In interviews with participants across the political spectrum, organizers were broadly aware of concurrent "site fights" (organizing efforts orbiting individual site proposals). In our interviews, participants often maintained coalition networks of site fights spanning hundreds of miles, sometimes virtually but also in-person: R6 traced for us a series of site fights across the state spanning 500 miles from their home county ("…this is happening everywhere [across Texas] […] we work with them too, right? Like all over the place…" (R6)); L2 similarly described traveling more than 100 miles each way to attend joint-organizing meetings with another data center action group; R3 told us about an hour-long roundtrip drive they had been frequently taking to help a site fight get established; L5 referred to helping site fights more than 600 miles away in their professional capacity as an environmental attorney.

Participants across the state and political formal and informal commitments communicate readily as well as travel hundreds of miles to help establish parallel nascent site fights, as well as help early organizing efforts get connected to the information-sharing network where organizers can share tips, successes, and collectively strategize & organize. Sometimes, shared information is tactical, as in L7's case where the information-sharing network helped them to identify the source and provenance of some equipment that had been trucked through another county: "…we found that [hyperscale data center project] out because some of […] the closed loop systems [were] coming down in a truck; somebody snapped a picture of it and […] we were able to look at the project number, get the address […] and yeah, it was Meta." (L7). In other cases, the information-sharing helps piece together and construct a clearer picture of the broader economic and political transformation that is taking place.

4.2.2 Participants manage political commitments and coalitions with intention. R1, R4, and R5 praised their left-leaning partners in organizing against data centers (for example, R1 told us that "…there's people on both sides of the political

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parties that agree and disagree." (R1) & R5, who described themselves as conservative, offered that "…some of our most reliable volunteers come from the local Democratic Party" (R5)); R2 relayed that they had reached out to and were in contact with the Caddo Nation, an Indigenous group that had historically lived on the land implicated in the data center's site; as well as environmental attorneys and the Sierra Club, an environmental advocacy group. L7 expressed their own surprise at some of the coalitions they were observing taking shape: "I [have] seen queer radicals and libertarians in a room working together […] Have I *ever* seen that before?" (L7).

While people are certainly willing to make coalitions across party lines, we also note that there are personal, ideological, and social boundaries many participants were careful to observe and reluctant to dissolve. R3 reflected on the prospect of working with the Sierra Club and demurred, citing that "the Sierra Club, and they do get money from Chinese-backed institutions. […] I know [Texans in the Sierra Club] […] do this out of their sincerity and all that, […] but I don't need the affiliation at all." (R3). L6 had countervailing misgivings, when we asked about the extent to which they were working with conservative organizers, if at all: "…you don't necessarily want to just bring [conservatives] into the group […] it *is* important to agree on this one issue […] but what happens if they drop a slur in the chat or something…" (L6).

4.2.3 Participants share notes and strategies. We heard from participants across the state who organized or communicated with regular community organizing meetings for the purpose of sharing notes and strategizing given developments from concurrent data center site fights. "…we have now been meeting for the last 5 months uh, at [REDACTED]. Um, every Thursday at 5:30. And we'll have 75 to 100 people there every week…" (R2); R2 described these weekly meetings as routinely welcoming guests from nearby counties and across the state to hear about developments in legal challenges to data center projects, and to think about how those developments might bear on R2's site fight. L2 & L7 both mentioned meeting regularly with organizers in two separate counties nearby, all organizing against their own hyperscale data center projects; L9 similarly mentioned having spent considerable time driving to and attending mass meetings in neighboring counties to learn and share insights from their own site fights.

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4.3 Converging Location and Dislocation

People engage in opposition to data centers in myriad ways; while we discuss some of those strategies in section 4.2, this section brings more focus specifically to the purposeful efforts to interrupt, disrupt, and stop data center projects in Texas.

4.3.1 Some participants reject dislocated logics entirely. Insofar as we may think about data centers through this lens of dislocating logics, we see people respond to the proposals of these dislocating projects by engaging purposefully in located thinking: as we mentioned earlier, participants carefully and deliberately manage their engagement and relationship with various potential coalitions; participants organize their fights around individual sites, foregrounding the specific features of each individual data center project; perhaps most consequentially, participants across the political spectrum — especially those who were actively engaged in organizing efforts — rejected or evaded the mapping of abstracted, dislocated partisanship onto tangible, real-world local data center site fights. We interpret these responses as rejections of the dislocating project of AI in much the same way that participants rejected techno-solutions such as closed loop cooling facilities as some sort of panacea.

4.3.2 At other times, participants engage strategically in dislocated logic to negotiate with or coerce data center developers to engage in located work. Many of the people we spoke with discussed the use of tax abatements (a reprieve or

exemption from certain taxes in exchange for various agreed-upon practices) to encourage data center developers to address the manifest problems with these facilities (e.g. noise mitigation and air quality monitoring). L5, R2, and others were involved in various forms of litigation to get courts either to demand more effort from data center developers about their best efforts to account for the comprehensive impacts of data centers on the surrounding area, or merely to stop the developments from moving forward. L9 told us about a handful of efforts to stop data centers from being developed, such as counties across the state attempting to pass moratoriums on data centers, and getting quickly rejected; but they also told us about one city's effort to functionally ban data centers when "…city council voted on [zoning] code to ban data centers from industrial land." (L9).

Across all of these examples, what we see are various forms of government (including very loose formulations of collective action and collective governance) for all practical purposes "negotiating" with the dislocated capitalist monolith that is a data center either by encouraging it with abatements (money) or threatening it with legal and regulatory constraints (e.g. moratoriums, re-zoning entire cities).

5 Discussion

5.1 The Dislocatedness of "AI" meets the Locatedness of Site Fights

The irreconcilable tension between AI as a dislocated, or actively dislocating, project; and data centers as located sites with comprehensive impacts on their surroundings precipitates a sort of crisis that may be fundamentally difficult for technologists to address. The proponents and advocates for data center projects may have managed to formulate ostensible responses to dismiss issues people raised with hyperscale data centers; but the people we spoke with were deeply unconvinced and ultimately quite disdainful of techno-solutionist answers to their concerns. Numerous participants brought up their frustration with what they characterized as a false solution in "closed loop" cooling technologies, as we found in section 4.1.

The sited nature of data centers makes them exceptionally activating. Where we spoke with participants who had not yet gotten involved in organizing efforts, we reflect that they rarely named sited targets upon which to focus their energy; although every participant we spoke with knew about data center projects near them, participants who told us they were not involved in organizing spoke more about *AI* than about those local data center projects. By contrast, many of the people we spoke with who had gotten involved in organizing spoke considerably more about the data center projects themselves, often citing literature and other materials that they had pulled together to familiarize themselves with the specific proposals. The emphasis of organizers on "site fights" underscores that these struggles are literally sited in specific places; they are not disembodied & abstracted, but located. In this way, data center development is perhaps fundamentally at a disadvantage against local organizers.

Data center developers' widespread use of myriad legal tools to suppress information about the data center project until it's too late to resist is both well-documented in reports and clearly reflected in our interviews. In section 4.1 we identified people's frustration at the use of corporate affiliates to obscure technology companies' interests, the use of non-disclosure agreements to isolate people and create information silos, and the compartmentalization and potentially the misclassification of sub-components of hyperscale data center projects. Organizers' responses to actively develop inter-regional coalitions and proactive information-sharing networks, which we reported in section 4.2, can be understood through this lens as a direct effort to address these strategies of dislocation.

Data centers may emerge as a focal point of increasing amounts of organizing and opposition; if that comes to pass, we expect that organizers will find success connecting conflicted or abjectly negative feelings about *AI* downward to

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the located site where *data centers* are proposed. Managing strategies to locate the community and the burdens they endure in contrast to myriad dislocated promises data center developers make, and tracing this disjuncture, may be a productive activating strategy. In other words, to turn potential collaborators into actual collaborators, successful organizers will find ways to locate people and organizing efforts.

6 Acknowledgments

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